

Penal Policy Winter 2016

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### "Four Sides of No Directions"

For this final project, I had an idea right away about the direction I would be moving towards. As an Indigenous person, a of the Oji-Cree communities of Island Lake and a band member of St. Theresa Point First Nation, I have been well aware of systematic issues that have been going on with regards to marginalizing and the affects this brings to Indigenous communities. I am also a mother and know that being an Indigenous woman exponentially puts me into a category of being far more likely to be imprisoned than my non-Indigenous counterparts. However, the statistics that we all talk about in classes and write in papers may not translate to all students, or people in general for that matter, that these umbers are actual people.

While reading "Justice Behind the Walls", in Section 4, there was a comment made by an inmate at Matsqui that had reminded me of these thoughts that I have. He said that he is a real person and that he would be leaving the institution one day, but they are not treated like people. When I think about how people are not treated as if they are a person, and especially if they are Indigenous and do not get the chance nor opportunity to engage in healing practices, when they return to the communities there may be no transformation for the better. I am hoping one day that there would be more availability in throughout the criminal justice system, because healing should be the focus as there has been a lot of factors that have impacted the over-representation of Indigenous people in Canadian institutions.

In my piece, I have focused on the plight of Indigenous women with regards to marginalization and impacts of colonization. Patriarchal colonial views have contributed to many policies dealing with "Indians" and Indigenous women have been displaced and suffered violence, as well as laterally in their communities. This is why the wooden box is covered in white leather, to represent the colonial & "white" views. There are chains to signify institutions and the beaded piece in the middle is a portrait, not of any particular woman but one that captures feeling of loneliness and disconnect while being in an institution. Especially when thinking about not only what can happen to her personally while being away, but as the centre and backbone to their families, where many Indigenous nations are matrilineal, or egalitarian at the very least.

Within the box, there is another story to unfold. As we have discussed in classes and read about, healing needs to come from within but it first starts with having the opportunities to do so. If the current system can move towards reconciling conflicting views with Indigenous communities on what rehabilitation looks like, it could shift current statistics and a the objects inside the box represent this. The inside is lined with floral fabric, looking like beads and representing a familiar style to many Indigenous communities. I also have a single "jingle" within the box

attached to a ribbon. A jingle can be found on jingle dresses, where there are 365 on a traditional dress to represent each day of the year and it is regarded as a healing dress that women or girls wear and dance to promote healing. (Also possibly 3<sup>rd</sup> gendered individuals)

There is also a CD inside, which has the "Strong Woman Song" and was sung by myself and another Indigenous law student, Brenda Schwab. This song resonates with the power of Indigenous woman and facing adversity, because it has roots in Kingston's Prison for Women. (P4W) This song was sung by Indigenous women to get through difficult times and is now sung across the land to honour all women. (I had planned to use a recording with more of my hand-drum group, but had issues with the recording device on that day)

Another item is a dreamcatcher, which has the colour pattern of the 4 directions. The dreamcatcher is used for children and youth to catch their dreams, an Anishinaabe story speaks of "spider woman" who had created them to help protect them from bad dreams when she was not able to after people began to spread over Turtle Island (North America). It was once her job to do this, but when the dreamcatchers were woven, they or their parents could place them over where they slept to catch the nightmares in the web and good ones could pass through the centre. They would then be released down and out of the feathers at the bottom. On this one I have made, I did not use a branch as traditionally used. (They are intended to break years after when a child no longer needs it) I decided to use a metal hoop but covered it with deer hide. I chose a material that would last longer because the theme of needing to have peace of mind at night, rings true for those in an institution. The colours of the 4 directions are yellow, black, red and white, which I have used and represent the East, South, West, and North. Women come from all over. Especially when there was only one Federal institution and a higher over-representation than their non-Indigenous counterparts and in comparison to men, many had come from all over, which still continues today.

Lastly, there is a medicine bag of the 4 colours. Within the medicine bag is the 4 medicines, which are cedar, sage, tobacco, and sweetgrass. When they are burned together, they can clear the mind and bring healing and a clear perspectives to people. As we had read about in "Justice Behind the Walls", they are powerful when helping inmates reconnect and heal themselves. They can also be used in the sweat lodge, but can also be carried in a medicine bag, which belong to individuals and should be respected. However, they are not always respected as we had read but it is important to try to teach this perspective to non-Indigenous administrative bodies. Since it is so important, I had made this and knew it was important when incorporating into this piece on Indigenous women but could speak to all people of all ages.

This concludes my project, which has been an emotional journey, as I have had family touched by the criminal justice system.